

CHARLES HARLESS
Software Engineering Manager
Technical Leadership • Cloud Platforms • Media Technology

Los Angeles, CA • 818-288-5313 • charles@harless.net • [linkedin.com/in/charless](https://www.linkedin.com/in/charless)

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Engineering leader with 15+ years building and scaling consumer, streaming, and cloud platforms at Disney, Amazon Prime Video, NBCUniversal, and Brightcove. Experienced leading engineering teams of up to 12 engineers and delivering platforms serving millions of consumers, 2,500+ enterprise customers, and 23,000+ global employees. Recognized for building high-performing teams, modernizing platform architectures, and translating business objectives into scalable engineering solutions.

KEY ACCOMPLISHMENTS

- Launched Disney Movies Anywhere, contributing to a platform that achieved 3.5M downloads within its first month and became the industry's first major cross-studio digital movie ecosystem
- Reduced engineering backlog by 75% within 30 days by implementing a data-driven prioritization framework
- Improved application performance by 25% through architecture modernization and targeted refactoring
- Increased engineering team engagement by 40% through coaching, feedback, and career development
- Reduced AWS operating costs by 15% through infrastructure optimization and cloud governance initiatives
- Coordinated remediation across 2,000+ applications within 1 week while maintaining production systems

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Engineering Consultant & Instructor Jul 2023 – Present

Thinking Bear Productions / UCLA Extension, Los Angeles, CA

- Advised organizations on engineering strategy, architecture, delivery, and operational improvement
- Conducted cloud optimization assessments identifying opportunities reducing AWS operating costs by 15%
- Guided engineering leaders in backlog restructuring and prioritization increasing team velocity by 20%
- Evaluated platform architectures and modernized distributed systems, cloud services, and CI/CD practices
- Designed and taught Java and Data Structures courses for 100+ software professionals at UCLA Extension, maintaining a 4.7/5.0 instructor rating

Software Engineering Manager Jan 2023 – Jun 2023

Brightcove, Boston, MA

- Led 2 engineering teams of 12 engineers delivering media management used by 2,500+ global customers
- Partnered with product management and customer success to rebuild engineering roadmap around highest-impact customer needs, directly resolving 3 at-risk enterprise accounts
- Reduced application latency by 25% and eliminated 75% of engineering backlog within 30 days through targeted refactoring and a structured prioritization framework
- Drove 40% improvement in team engagement through coaching, feedback, and individual growth plans
- Introduced automated testing and release quality controls that reduced change failure rates by 25%

Software Development Manager Jan 2021 – Jun 2022

Amazon Prime Video, Culver City, CA

- Managed a team of 8 engineers building AWS-based services for a global media supply chain platform
- Defined and executed a 3-year engineering roadmap in partnership with product, legal, and business development leaders supporting more than 800 global content distribution agreements
- Established a scalable intake, prioritization, and dependency-management process across multiple engineering teams, improving team engagement and delivery velocity by 30%
- Partnered with program management and security teams to coordinate remediation rollout across 2,000+ internal applications, completed in under 1 week with zero production incidents
- Grew team capability through hiring 2 engineers and internally promoting 2 engineers to senior roles
- Drove technical planning and architectural decisions for AWS-based media supply chain services supporting global content distribution workflows

Staff Software Engineer (Technical Lead)

Apr 2016 – Dec 2020

NBCUniversal, Universal City, CA

- Technical lead managing 6 engineers developing employee mobile apps supporting 23,000+ employees
- Owned engineering roadmap for employee platforms partnering with product and leadership to prioritize a backlog spanning 5+ concurrent workstreams
- Redesigned employee notification systems, improving engagement by 10% and reducing opt-outs by 20% across a 23,000-person user base
- Defined engineering standards, API design guidelines, and CI/CD patterns adopted across the organization
- Partnered with HR and internal communications leadership to align platform delivery to enterprise business goals; improvements to employee tooling contributed to measurable gains in workforce engagement
- Provided technical leadership across mobile, API, and backend services supporting a global employee platform used by more than 23,000 employees
- Collaborated with architecture and security teams to modernize mobile platform infrastructure

Staff Software Engineer (Technical Lead)

Nov 2011 – Feb 2014

Walt Disney Studios, Burbank, CA

- Led 2 teams of 6 engineers for consumer digital platforms including Disney Movies Anywhere; responsible for streaming architecture, DRM, and infrastructure reliability
- Led engineering delivery for Disney Movies Anywhere, contributing to a platform that achieved 3.5M downloads in its first month and grew into one of the industry's largest digital movie ecosystems
- Deployed high-availability streaming infrastructure with 99.9% uptime serving 4TB of content
- Implemented adaptive bitrate streaming (HLS/DASH) and DRM (Widevine, FairPlay) for security
- Mentored several senior engineers in navigating career paths with promotion to staff level
- Managed a \$1M project budget, delivered project on schedule, within scope, and within budget
- Partnered with studio and technology stakeholders to deliver secure digital ownership and streaming experiences across web, mobile, and connected device platforms

Senior Software Engineer

Dec 2005 – Oct 2011

Walt Disney Parks & Resorts, Glendale, CA

- Built and maintained consumer-facing website supporting Disney Parks digital experiences
- Delivered multiple large-scale web applications supporting consumer transactions and digital experiences
- Established architecture standards and development practices adopted across engineering teams
- Contributed to 12 award-winning consumer platforms emphasizing scalability, reliability, and maintainability

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

- **Master of Science in Computer Science** – University of California, Los Angeles
- **Bachelor of Science in Computer Science** – University of Alabama
- **Certified ScrumMaster (CSM) & Certified Scrum Product Owner (CSPO)** – Scrum Alliance
- **AWS Cloud Practitioner Essentials** – Amazon Web Services
- **Generative AI Fundamentals** – Databricks

AREAS OF EXPERTISE

- **Technical Leadership:** Distributed Systems, Cloud Architecture, Platform Modernization, Scalability & Reliability, Software Architecture, Technical Strategy
- **Product Delivery:** Engineering Roadmaps, Resource Planning, OKR-Driven Delivery, Agile/Scrum, Organizational Design, Cross-functional Leadership
- **Enterprise Architecture:** Microservices, REST APIs, Event-Driven Systems, Generative AI Integration
- **Cloud & Infrastructure:** AWS (Lambda, ECS, S3, API Gateway), Docker, Cost Governance
- **Streaming Media:** HLS, DASH, DRM (Widevine & FairPlay), CDNs, Adaptive Bitrate Delivery
- **Languages & Frameworks:** Java, Spring Boot, Node.js, TypeScript, JavaScript, React
- **Developer Tools:** GitHub, Jenkins, Jira, Confluence, SQL, MongoDB, CI/CD, Automation